

PROMPTING GUIDE FOR CTE INSTRUCTORS

The Prompting Playbook

A practical framework and trade-specific starter prompts for getting useful results from Microsoft Copilot — built for hands-on CTE classrooms.

Why prompting is a teachable skill

Copilot doesn't read your mind — it reads your words. The gap between a flat, generic answer and a genuinely useful one is almost always the prompt, not the tool. The good news: prompting well is a skill you can teach in five minutes and reuse for the rest of the term.

A four-part frame: Role, Task, Context, Format

Before you type, answer four questions. You don't need to label them in the prompt — just make sure all four show up somewhere in what you type.

- **Role** — Who should Copilot act as? ("Act as a curriculum coach for a 9th-grade welding program.")
- **Task** — What exactly do you want produced? Be specific about the verb: draft, revise, shorten, quiz, translate, critique.
- **Context** — What does it need to know about your students, your program, your standards, or your constraints?
- **Format** — What should the output look like? A table, a bulleted list, a one-page handout, a rubric with four rows?

Example: "Act as a curriculum coach for a 9th-grade welding program. Draft a 5-question exit ticket on shielded metal arc welding safety for students reading two grade levels behind. Format it as a numbered list with an answer key underneath."

Trade-specific starter prompts

Copy, paste, and swap in your own topic, standard, or student population. These are written to be used as-is in Copilot Chat.

Trade / Pathway	Try this prompt
Welding / Metals	Act as a CTE instructor. Write three real-world scenarios where a welder must choose between MIG and TIG based on material and joint type. Format as a matching activity for beginners.

Culinary Arts	Act as a culinary program advisor. Create a costing worksheet prompt list a student could use to price out a 4-item lunch menu for a school-run café, including a 30% food cost target.
Cosmetology	Draft a client-consultation script a cosmetology student can practice, covering allergy questions, service expectations, and one upsell opportunity, in plain conversational language.
Automotive / Collision Repair	Act as a shop foreman. Write a 10-item pre-inspection checklist for a brake job appropriate for a first-year student, in the order a technician would actually work through it.
Health Science	Create six short patient scenarios for practicing vital-sign documentation, each with one deliberate red-flag value a nursing student should catch.
Construction / Trades	Write a toolbox talk (under 200 words) on ladder safety appropriate to read aloud at the start of a shop period, in a tone that sounds like a real supervisor, not a textbook.
Agriculture	Draft three troubleshooting scenarios for a small engine that won't start, ordered from most to least common cause, for a student working through a diagnostic flowchart.

When the first answer isn't good enough

Don't start over — refine. These follow-ups work in almost any conversation:

- *"Make this shorter — one paragraph, not three."*
- *"Rewrite this at a 6th-grade reading level."*
- *"Add a version of this for a student using a wheelchair in the shop."*
- *"This is too generic — reference [your specific equipment / standard / local employer] instead."*
- *"Give me three alternatives, not just one."*

Common pitfalls

- **Too vague:** "Help me with a lesson on welding" gives Copilot almost nothing to work with. Name the topic, grade band, and format.
- **No context on your students:** Copilot doesn't know your class unless you tell it — reading levels, IEP accommodations, prior units covered.

- **Treating the first draft as final:** Always verify technical, safety, and code-related details against your official curriculum and current industry standards before using it with students.
- **Skipping the follow-up:** The second and third prompt in a conversation are usually where the useful version shows up.

Blank template — fill this in before you open Copilot

Role	Act as a _____ for a _____ program.
Task	Draft / revise / shorten / quiz / critique _____.
Context	My students _____. We just covered _____.
Format	Give it to me as a _____.